THE TWELVE CHAMPIONS

1975
West Indies

1979
West Indies

1983
India

1987/88
Australia

1991/92
Pakistan

1995/96
Sri Lanka

1999
Australia

2002/03
Australia

2006/07
Australia

2010/11
India

2014/15
Australia

2019
England

A DATA STORY · EXPLORATORY DATA ANALYSIS

Twelve World Cups, One Dataset.

Forty-four years of men's Cricket World Cup history, read through 454 matches: who wins, how scores have changed, and what really separates the champions from the rest.

454	20	12	6
matches	teams	editions	champions

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Project report · Python, Pandas, Matplotlib, Seaborn

Source: worldcup_dataset.csv · October 2026

The story in one page

Eight things the 454 matches tell us, before we look at any chart.

Between 1975 and 2019 the men's World Cup grew from a 15-match experiment into a 50-match festival. Underneath the headlines, the data shows a tournament with a clear pecking order, rising scores, and very few truly close finishes. These are the eight findings this report builds on.

1 Tripled, then stopped
Matches per edition went from 15 (1975) to 54 (2002/03), then settled at 48–51.

2 One team stands apart
Australia: 5 titles, 69 wins, 74.2% of completed matches won.

3 Wins are not trophies
New Zealand (54 wins) and South Africa (38) have never lifted the Cup.

4 Setting a target helps a little
Batting first won 54.1% of the 431 matches decided on the field.

5 Scores keep climbing
Average first innings: 238 in 1975, 266 in 2019; all four 400+ totals came in 2006/07 or 2014/15.

6 Two tiers
29% of matches involved a smaller team; established sides won about 85% of them.

7 Nail-biters are rare
Only 16 of 431 decided matches (3.7%) ended by 5 runs or fewer, or by one wicket.

8 England is the home of the game
Six of the seven busiest grounds are English.

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Data & preparation

What the CSV looked like, and what had to change before it could be trusted.

THE RAW FILE

One row per match, 454 rows, 15 columns, 12 tournaments from 1975 to 2019. Every column arrived as text, including the scores.

Column	What it holds	Gaps
date, season	Match date, tournament year	0
host, stadium, series	Host label, ground, sponsor-era name	0
match_type	Match number or knockout stage	0
team_1, team_2	The two sides (team_1 batted first)	0
team_1_score, team_2_score	Scores like “311 for 8”	9 / 14
winner	Team name or result label	0
margin, margin_type	Size of the win, in runs or wickets	0
winning_condition	Balls remaining, D/L, walkover	235
season_winner	Champion of that edition	0

OUTCOME OF THE 454 MATCHES



436 decided (96%, five by walkover) · **8** no result · **5** abandoned · **5** tied

Win percentages in this report use only the 436 decided matches, so a rained-off game never counts against a team.

SIX STEPS FROM RAW TO READY

1 Parse the scores

“311 for 8” became runs = 311 and wickets = 8 for each team; a bare “207” means all out (10 wickets).

2 Tidy the labels

run/runs and wicket/wickets were merged; “won” and “default” were recognised as walkovers.

3 Separate non-results

“No result”, “Match tied” and abandoned games moved out of the winner column into an outcome field.

4 Fix the timeline

Dates arrive in several formats, so the season column became the reliable time key.

5 Check the batting order

Every run-margin win belongs to team_1 and 99.5% of wicket wins to team_2, so team_1 = batted first.

6 Flag odd labels

“Super Eights” (24 rows) is a stage, not a ground, and is excluded from venue counts.

THE CORE OF THE CLEANING CODE

```
def parse_score(s):
    if pd.isna(s): return (np.nan, np.nan)
    m = re.match(r"(\d+)(?: for (\d+))?", str(s).strip())
    return int(m.group(1)), (int(m.group(2)) if m.group(2) else 10)

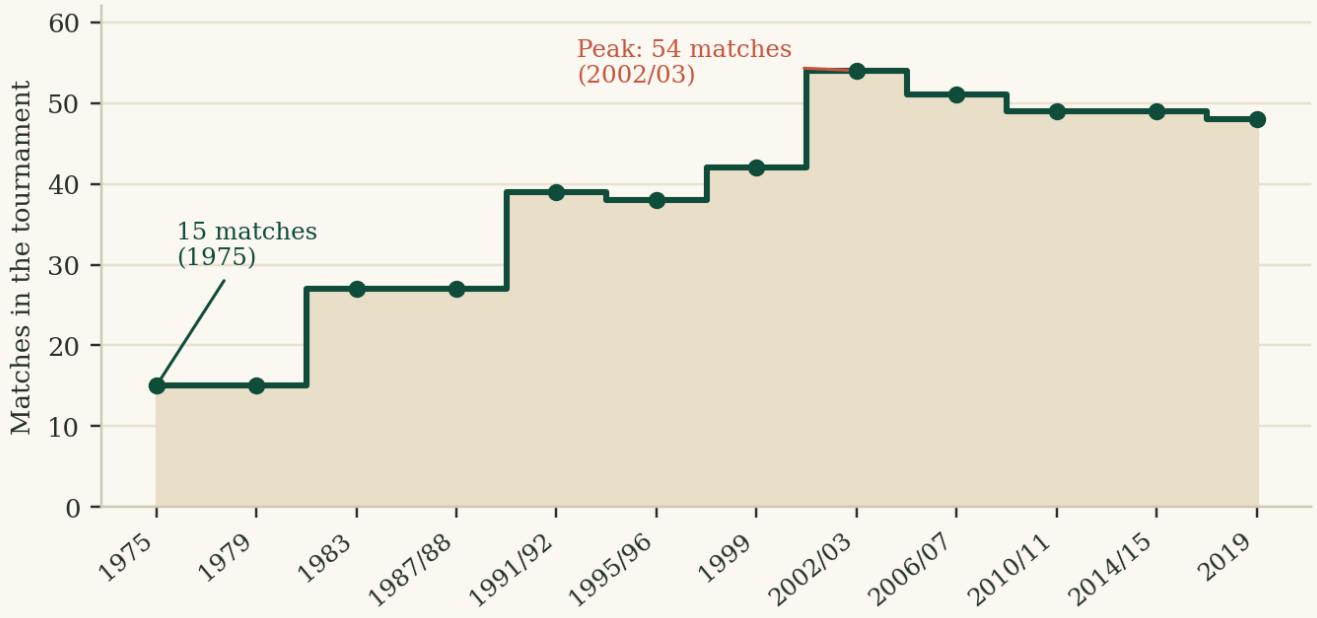
df["margin_type"] = df["margin_type"].str.lower()
df["outcome"] = np.select([df.margin_type.str.contains("tied"), df.margin_type.str.contains("no result"),
                           df.margin_type.str.contains("abandon")], ["Tied","No result","Abandoned"], default="Result")
```

01

A tournament that grew up

From eight teams and 15 matches in England to a month-long, 50-match event on every continent that plays the game.

The first two World Cups were short, sharp affairs: 15 matches each, played in England. Eight years later the field and the calendar had both expanded, and by 2002/03 the tournament peaked at **54 matches**, a 3.6-fold increase. Since then the organisers have held it steady at 48 to 51 matches, which suggests the format found its natural size rather than simply continuing to grow.



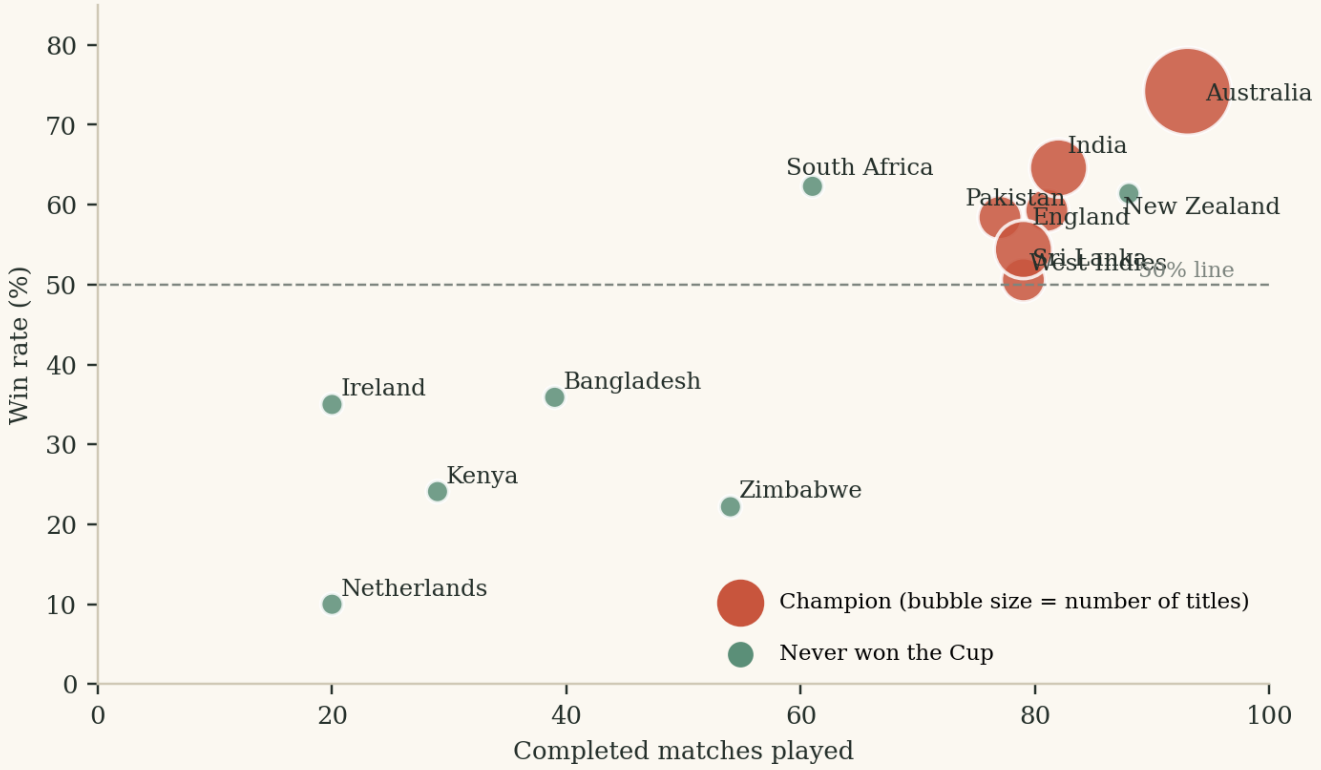
Edition	Title sponsor / name	Host(s)	Matches	Champion
1975	Prudential	England	15	**West Indies**
1979	Prudential	England	15	**West Indies**
1983	Prudential	England	27	**India**
1987/88	Reliance	India / Pakistan	27	**Australia**
1991/92	Benson & Hedges	Australia / New Zealand	39	**Pakistan**
1995/96	Wills	India / Pakistan / Sri Lanka	38	**Sri Lanka**
1999	ICC World Cup	England + Ireland, Netherlands, Scotland	42	**Australia**
2002/03	ICC World Cup	Kenya / South Africa / Zimbabwe	54	**Australia**
2006/07	ICC World Cup	West Indies	51	**Australia**
2010/11	ICC Cricket World Cup	Bangladesh / India / Sri Lanka	49	**India**
2014/15	ICC Cricket World Cup	Australia / New Zealand	49	**Australia**
2019	ICC Cricket World Cup	England	48	**England**

> *Seven of the twelve editions were co-hosted. Sharing the tournament became the rule, not the exception.*

02 Who wins the matches?

Every team's record across all 12 editions, plotted as volume against efficiency.

Plotting completed matches against win rate separates the field cleanly. **Australia** sits alone at the top right: the most matches and the highest win rate. Next comes a pack of established sides between 50% and 65%. Bangladesh and Zimbabwe trail well behind them, and the smaller teams cluster below 40% with a few matches each. Orange bubbles are champions; the bigger the bubble, the more titles.



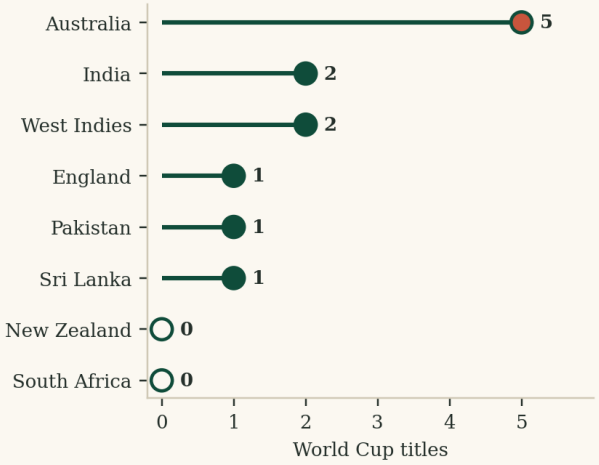
Team	Played	Won	Lost	No result / tied	Win %	Titles
Australia	93	69	24	3	**74.2%**	5
India	82	53	29	3	**64.6%**	2
South Africa	61	38	23	3	**62.3%**	0
New Zealand	88	54	34	3	**61.4%**	0
England	81	48	33	3	**59.3%**	1
Pakistan	77	45	32	3	**58.4%**	1
West Indies	79	43	36	3	**54.4%**	2
Sri Lanka	79	40	39	6	**50.6%**	1
Bangladesh	39	14	25	3	**35.9%**	0
Zimbabwe	54	12	42	4	**22.2%**	0

Table sorted by win rate. "Played" counts completed matches; ties, no-results and abandoned games are shown separately. Walkover wins count as wins.

The efficiency ranking tells a different story from the raw win count. India and South Africa both overtake New Zealand once the number of matches is taken into account: South Africa reached 38 wins from just 61 completed matches, a rate no team except Australia and India beats.

03 The trophy cabinet

Six nations have won the Cup; two of the best match-winners have not.



> *Australia's five titles are more than any two rivals combined.*

The lollipops show how concentrated success is. Australia has 5, India and West Indies 2 each, and England, Pakistan and Sri Lanka 1. New Zealand and South Africa, second and eighth by wins, are still waiting.

HOW EACH CHAMPION GOT THERE

Edition	Champion	Record	Win %	The final
1975	**West Indies**	5 of 5	100%	beat Australia by 17 runs
1979	**West Indies**	4 of 4	100%	beat England by 92 runs
1983	**India**	6 of 8	75%	beat West Indies by 43 runs
1987/88	**Australia**	7 of 8	88%	beat England by 7 runs
1991/92	**Pakistan**	6 of 9	67%	beat England by 22 runs
1995/96	**Sri Lanka**	8 of 8	100%	beat Australia by 7 wickets
1999	**Australia**	7 of 9	78%	beat Pakistan by 8 wickets
2002/03	**Australia**	11 of 11	100%	beat India by 125 runs
2006/07	**Australia**	11 of 11	100%	beat Sri Lanka by 53 runs
2010/11	**India**	7 of 8	88%	beat Sri Lanka by 6 wickets
2014/15	**Australia**	7 of 8	88%	beat New Zealand by 7 wickets
2019	**England**	7 of 10	70%	final tied with New Zealand; won on tie-break

Record = wins from completed matches in that tournament, walkovers included for Sri Lanka 1995/96. England's 2019 record excludes the tied final.

What stands out: five champions were unbeaten in completed matches (West Indies in 1975 and 1979, Sri Lanka in 1995/96 with the help of walkovers, and Australia in both 2002/03 and 2006/07). Ten of the twelve winners won at least 75% of their matches. The two exceptions, Pakistan in 1991/92 and England in 2019, each lost three games along the way, which shows that a team can still peak in the knockout stage and win.

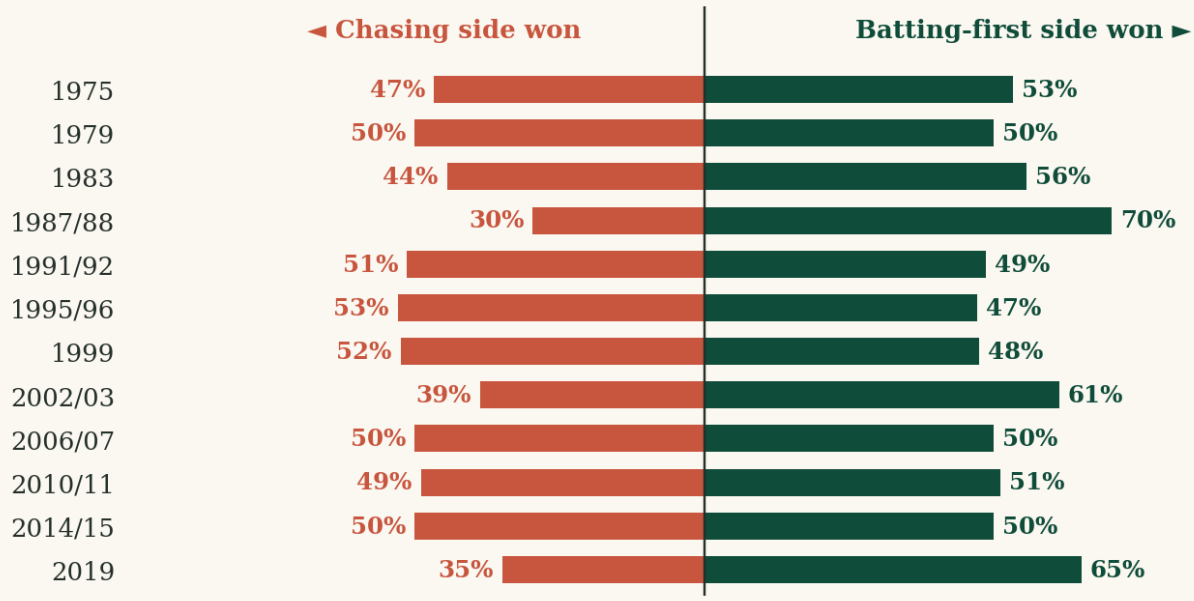
04 Bat first or chase?

Because team_1 is the side that batted first, every win by runs is a defended total and every win by wickets is a chase.

54.1%
of 431 on-field results won by the team batting first (233 matches)

45.9%
won by the chasing side (198 matches)

70%
batting-first wins in 1987/88, the strongest edition for defending



The split is close to a coin toss with a slight lean. In ten of the twelve editions the difference between the two columns is under 15 points, and in four of them (1991/92, 1995/96, 1999, and 2006/07 and 2014/15 at exactly 50%) chasing was as good as or better than setting a target. The two outliers are **1987/88** (70% for the side batting first) and **2019** (65%).

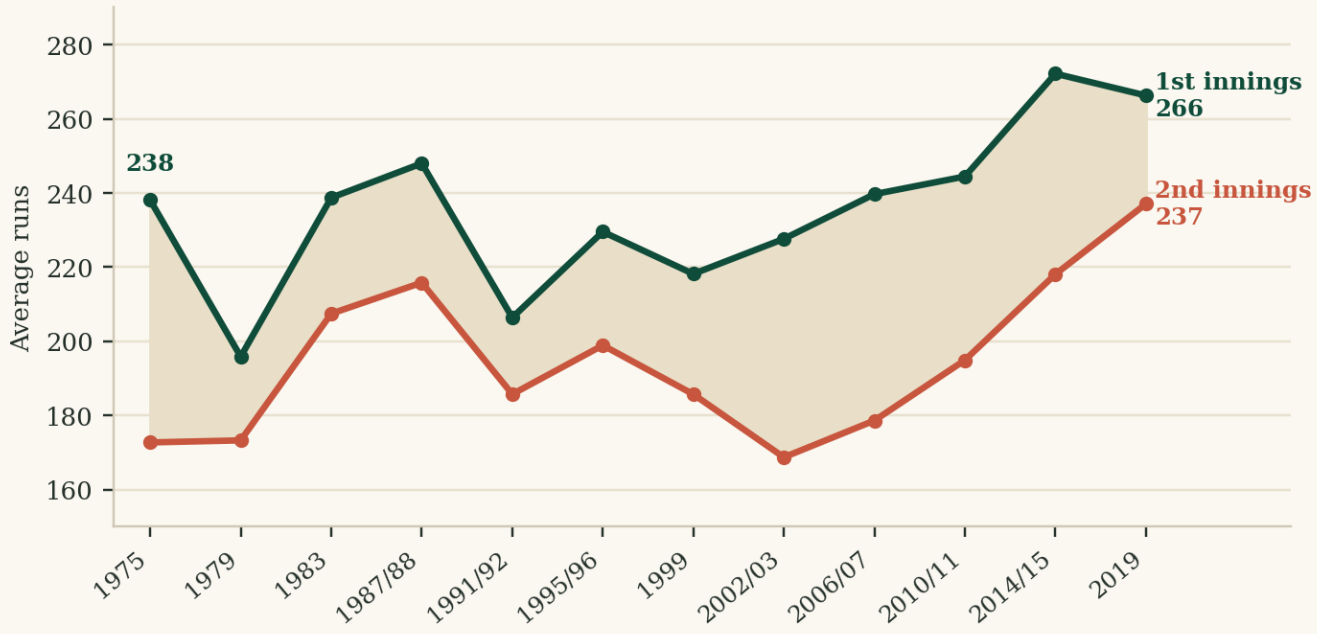
> *A 54/46 split is a lean, not a rule. Team quality matters far more than batting order.*

A caution. The file has no toss column, so we cannot say whether a team chose to bat first or was told to. Rain-affected matches (28 decided by the Duckworth–Lewis method or a revised target) also blur the comparison.

05 The scoreboard keeps climbing

Average innings totals, edition by edition, and the biggest scores ever recorded.

In 1975 the average first innings was 238 (a 60-over match). It fell to 196 in 1979 and 206 in 1991/92, then rose steadily to **272 in 2014/15** and 266 in 2019. The orange line, the chasing side's average, has risen faster: the gap between the two innings shrank from 59 runs in 2002/03 to just 29 in 2019, so chasing teams are getting much closer to the targets they are set.



TEN HIGHEST INNINGS TOTALS

Score	Team v opponent	Edition
417/6	Australia v Afghanistan	2014/15
413/5	India v Bermuda	2006/07
411/4	South Africa v Ireland	2014/15
408/5	South Africa v West Indies	2014/15
398/5	Sri Lanka v Kenya	1995/96
397/6	England v Afghanistan	2019
393/6	New Zealand v West Indies	2014/15
386/6	England v Bangladesh	2019
381/5	Australia v Bangladesh	2019
377/6	Australia v South Africa	2006/07

BIGGEST WINS BY RUNS

Runs	Winner v opponent	Edition
275	Australia v Afghanistan	2014/15
257	South Africa v West Indies	2014/15
257	India v Bermuda	2006/07
256	Australia v Namibia	2002/03
243	Sri Lanka v Bermuda	2006/07
231	South Africa v Netherlands	2010/11

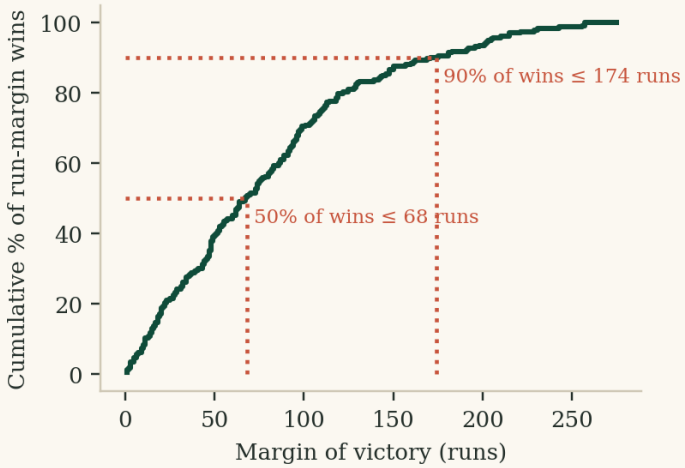
Lowest all-out totals: 36 (Canada v Sri Lanka, 2003), then 45 by Canada (v England, 1979) and by Namibia (v Australia, 2003).

All four scores above 400 came against a smaller side or a team that was heavily beaten (Afghanistan, Bermuda, Ireland, West Indies). Six of the ten highest totals are from the last two editions, which fits the story of modern batting: bigger bats, fielding restrictions and fearless hitting, helped along by mismatched fixtures.

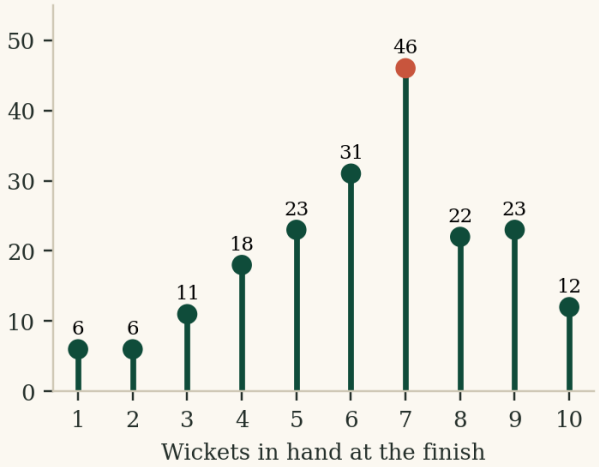
06 Margins and nail-biters

Most matches are won clearly. The tight ones are what people remember.

How big are wins by runs?



How comfortable are chases?



Half of all wins by runs are by 68 runs or more (the median), and one in ten is by about 160 or more. Chases are usually comfortable too: the most common finish is with seven wickets in hand, and twelve chases ended with all ten in hand. By contrast, only **16 of 431** decided matches (3.7%) were won by 5 runs or fewer, or by a single wicket.

WON BY 1–5 RUNS (10)

Match	Margin
Australia v India, 1987/88	1 run
Australia v India, 1991/92	1 run
Sri Lanka v England, 2006/07	2 runs
West Indies v South Africa, 2002/03	3 runs
New Zealand v Zimbabwe, 1987/88	3 runs
Australia v New Zealand, 1987/88	3 runs
Zimbabwe v India, 1999	3 runs
Australia v West Indies, 1995/96	5 runs
Ireland v Zimbabwe, 2014/15	5 runs
New Zealand v West Indies, 2019	5 runs

WON BY 1 WICKET (6)

Match	Winner
West Indies v Pakistan, 1975	West Indies
West Indies v Pakistan, 1987/88	Pakistan
Sri Lanka v South Africa, 2006/07	South Africa
West Indies v England, 2006/07	England
Scotland v Afghanistan, 2014/15	Afghanistan
Australia v New Zealand, 2014/15	New Zealand

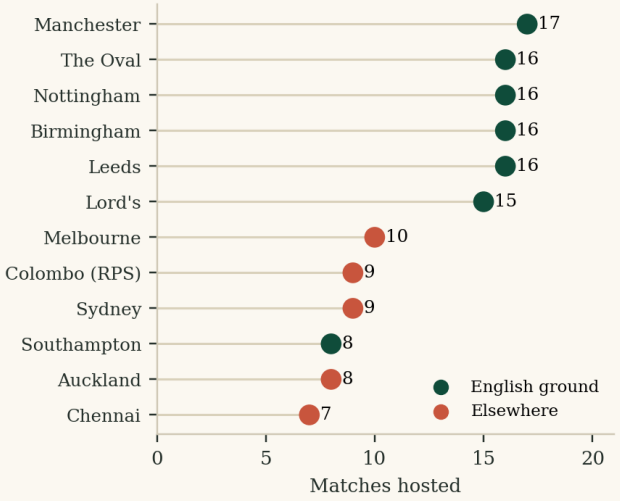
TIED (5)

Match	Edition
Australia v South Africa (semi-final)	1999
Sri Lanka v South Africa (D/L)	2002/03
Ireland v Zimbabwe	2006/07
India v England	2010/11
New Zealand v England (final)	2019

The 2019 final, tied and then settled on the tie-break, is the only tied final in the data.

07 Where and against whom

The grounds that host the tournament, the rivalries that repeat, and the gap between established and smaller teams.



English grounds dominate. Manchester (17), The Oval, Nottingham, Birmingham and Leeds (16 each) and Lord's (15) are six of the seven busiest grounds. Outside England the busiest is Melbourne with 10. England's lead is simple arithmetic: it hosted four editions alone and shared a fifth.

Host label	Editions
England	4
Australia / New Zealand	2
Six other single or joint hosts	1 each

MOST FREQUENT MATCH-UPS

Pairing	Played	Record
Australia v India	12	Australia 8, India 4
Pakistan v West Indies	11	West Indies 8, Pakistan 3
Australia v Sri Lanka	11	Australia 8, Sri Lanka 2, 1 no result
Australia v New Zealand	11	Australia 8, New Zealand 3
New Zealand v Sri Lanka	11	Sri Lanka 6, New Zealand 5
England v Sri Lanka	11	England 6, Sri Lanka 5
England v Pakistan	10	Pakistan 5, England 4, 1 no result
Australia v West Indies	10	5–5

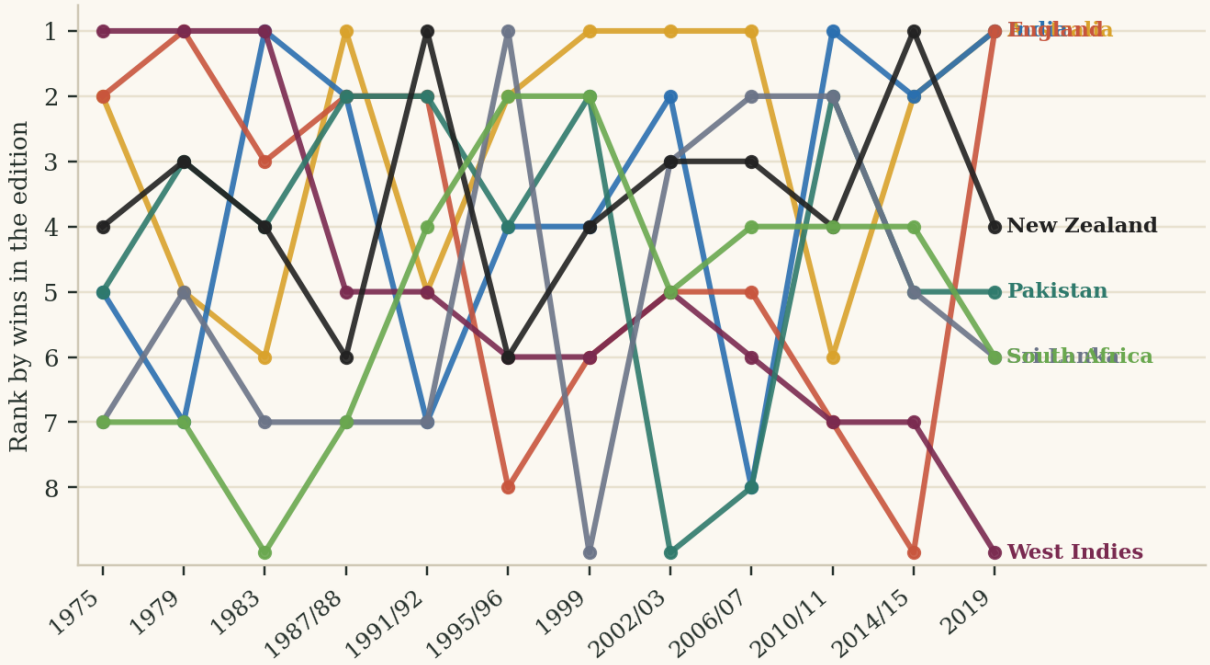
84.6%

of the 130 decided matches involving a team outside the ten established sides were won by the established side (110 matches). Kenya, Ireland, Canada, the Netherlands, Afghanistan and the UAE share just 20 wins.

"Established" here is the author's grouping of the ten teams that played regularly (Australia, England, India, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, South Africa, New Zealand, West Indies, Zimbabwe and Bangladesh); it is not an official ICC list. About 29% of all matches (132 of 454) involved at least one team outside that group, and the biggest wins and highest totals come disproportionately from those fixtures.

08 Rise, fall and the era map

Rank by wins in each edition, then the full team-by-edition table of wins.



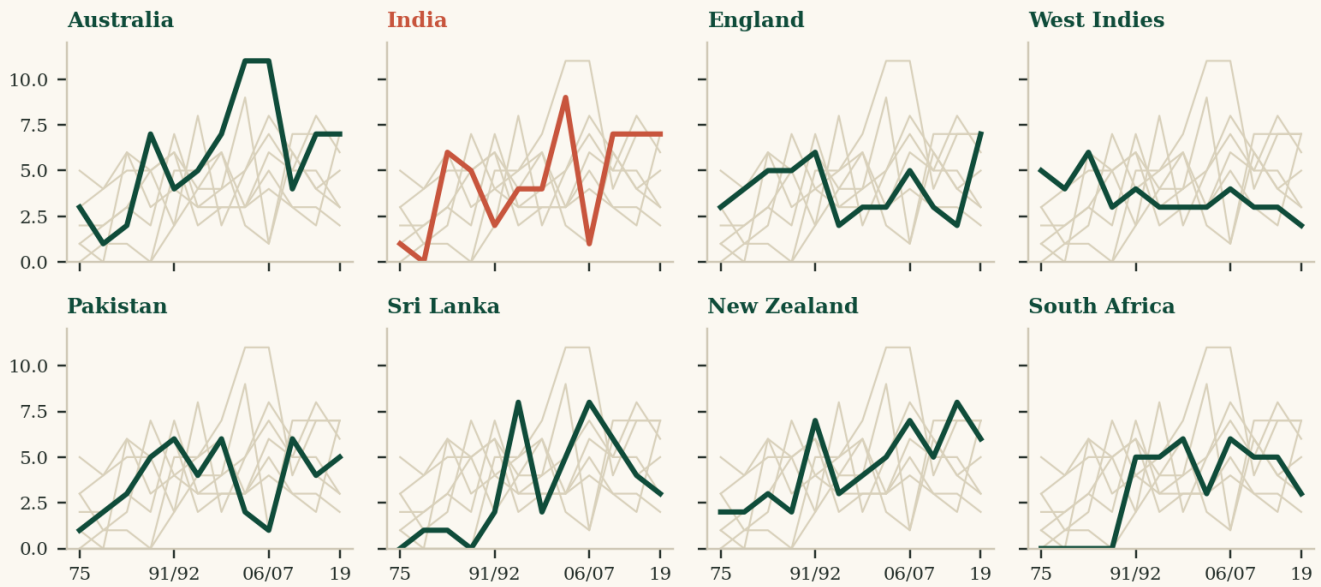
Read the lines top to bottom: rank 1 means the most wins in that edition. West Indies led in 1975 and 1983, Australia took over from 1987/88 and held the top spot in 2002/03 and 2006/07, while Sri Lanka and South Africa each had a sustained peak in the mid-1990s and late 2000s.

	Australia	New Zealand	India	England	Pakistan	West Indies	Sri Lanka	South Africa	Bangladesh	Zimbabwe
1975	3	2	1	3	1	5	0	0	0	0
1979	1	2	0	4	2	4	1	0	0	0
1983	2	3	6	5	3	6	1	0	0	1
1987/88	7	2	5	5	5	3	0	0	0	0
1991/92	4	7	2	6	6	4	2	5	0	1
1995/96	5	3	4	2	4	3	8	5	0	1
1999	7	4	4	3	6	3	2	6	2	3
2002/03	11	5	9	3	2	3	5	3	0	3
2006/07	11	7	1	5	1	4	8	6	3	0
2010/11	4	5	7	3	6	3	6	5	3	2
2014/15	7	8	7	2	4	3	4	5	3	1
2019	7	6	7	7	5	2	3	3	3	0

Darker green = more wins. Australia’s 11 wins in both 2002/03 and 2006/07 are the highest single-edition counts. Bangladesh has three wins in each of the last four editions; Zimbabwe has never passed three.

India spotlight & the verdict

Eight teams, one line each. India is highlighted; the rest are in grey for comparison.



India won one match in 1975, lifted the trophy in 1983 with six wins, recorded a high of **nine wins in 2002/03** and then a one-win slump in 2006/07. It has won seven matches in each of the last three editions (2010/11, 2014/15, 2019), the steadiest run in its history, and took the 2010/11 title along the way.

LIMITATIONS

- The data ends with the 2019 edition and covers men's World Cups only.
- There is no toss, player, pitch or ball-by-ball information.
- Team 1 is inferred to be the side batting first; this holds in virtually every match.
- 28 rain-affected matches are not directly comparable.
- 60-over (1975–83) and 50-over editions are mixed.
- Teams with few matches have win rates that swing on a single result.

NEXT STEPS

- Add the 2023 men's and the women's World Cups.
- Add toss, player of the match and real grounds for stage labels.
- Test batting-first vs chasing with toss and conditions data.
- Rate teams with an Elo-style system to compare eras fairly.
- Predict match winners with logistic regression or a random forest.
- Publish an interactive Power BI or Tableau dashboard.

> *From 454 rows to one clear story: Australia's dominance, a field that splits into two tiers, and a game whose scores keep rising.*